Night Sky with Exit Wounds

(Selections from)

By Ocean Vuong

INTRODUCTION

Near the end of the Vietnam War in 1975, people in South Vietnam began to flee due to the rise of communism in Vietnam. Armed Forces Radio played Irving Berlin's "White Christmas" as a code to begin the evacuation of American civilians and Vietnamese refugees during the fall of Saigon. Ocean Vuong and his family were among those refugees.

Selections from Night Sky with Exit Wounds by Ocean Vuong

Aubade with Burning City

Milkflower petals on the street
like pieces of a girl's dress.

Some grenades explode with a vision of white flowers. Baby's breath blooming in a darkened sky, across my chest.

– From Notebook Fragments

May your days be merry and bright…*

He fills a teacup with champagne, brings it to her lips.

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Open, he says.
She opens.
Outside, a soldier spits out his cigarette as footsteps fill the square like stones
fallen from the sky. ***May all your Christmases be white***
as the traffic guard unstraps his holster.

His hand running the hem
of her white dress. A single candle.
Their shadows: two wicks.

A military truck speeds through the intersection, children
shrieking inside. A bicycle hurled
through a store window. When the dust rises, a black dog
lies panting in the road. Its hind legs
crushed into the shine
of a white Christmas.

On the bed stand, a sprig of magnolia expands like a secret heard
for the first time.

The treetops glisten and children listen, the chief of police
facedown in a pool of Coca-Cola.
A palm-sized photo of his father soaking beside his left ear.

The song moving through the city like a widow.
A white... A white... I'm dreaming of a curtain of
snow

falling from her shoulders.

Snow scraping against the window. Snow shredded
with gunfire. Red sky.
Snow on the tanks rolling over the city walls.
A helicopter lifting the living just
out of reach.

The city so white it is ready for ink.

The radio saying run run run.
Milkflower petals on a black dog
like pieces of a girl's dress.

May your days be merry and bright. She is saying
something neither of them can hear. The hotel
rocks
beneath them. The bed a field of ice.

Don't worry, he says, as the first shell flashes
their faces, ***my brothers have won the war***
and tomorrow...
The lights go out.

I'm dreaming. I'm dreaming...
to hear sleigh bells in the snow...

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In the square below: a nun, on fire,
runs silently toward her god—

Open, he says.
She opens.

******

When we left it, the city was still smoldering. Otherwise it was a perfect spring morning. White hyacinths gasped in the embassy lawn. The sky was September-blue and the pigeons went on pecking at bits of bread scattered from the bombed bakery. Broken baguettes. Crushed croissants. Gutted cars. A carousel spinning its blackened horses. He said the shadow of missiles growing larger on the sidewalk looked like god playing an air piano above us. He said ***There is so much I need to tell you.***

– From Immigrant Haibun

TRANSITION

But those words of wisdom would never come.

Ocean Vuong once said: Fragments are what make my life. I gather them all together in my arms and carry what I can: Here is where things have become disastrous; here is where I learned to live through the pain; here is where I've come to stand, knees trembling, after being bent double in grief.

Grief for Vietnam and grief for his father.

Telemachus

Like any good son, I pull my father out
of the water, drag him by his hair

through white sand, his knuckles carving a trail
the waves rush in to erase. Because the city

beyond the shore is no longer
where he left it. Because the bombed

cathedral is now a cathedral
of trees. I kneel beside him to see how far

I might sink. *Do you know who I am,*
Ba? But the answer never comes. The answer

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is the bullet hole in his back, brimming
with seawater. He is so still I think

he could be anyone's father, found
the way a green bottle might appear

at a boy's feet containing a year
he has never touched. I touch

his ears. No use. I turn him
over. To face it. The Cathedral

in his sea-black eyes.
I begin the faithful work
of drowning.

TRANSITION

Although Ocean Vuong never stepped foot on the active battlefields of Vietnam, the reality of the war that drove his family from his homeland is still there. Memories still haunt him.

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Self-Portrait with Exit Wounds

Instead, let it be the echo to every footstep
drowned out by rain, cripple the air like a name

flung onto a sinking boat, splash the kapok's bark
through rot & iron of a city trying to forget

the bones beneath its sidewalks, then through
the refugee camp sick with smoke & half-sung

hymns, a shack rusted black & lit with Bà Ngoại's
last candle, the hogs' faces we held in our hands

& mistook for brothers, let it enter a room illuminated
with snow, furnished only with laughter, Wonder Bread

& mayonnaise raised to cracked lips as testament
to a triumph no one recalls, let it brush the newborn's

flushed cheek as he's lifted in his father's arms,
wreathed
with fishgut & Marlboros, everyone cheering as another

brown gook crumbles under John Wayne's M16, Vietnam
burning on the screen, let it slide through their ears,

clean, like a promise, before piercing the poster
of Michael Jackson glistening over the couch, into

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the supermarket where a Hapa woman is ready
to believe every white man possessing her nose

is her father, may it sing, briefly, inside her mouth,
before laying her down between jars of tomato

& blue boxes of pasta, the deep-red apple . . .

In Vietnamese, the word for grenade is "bom," from the French "pomme," meaning "apple" . . . Or was it American for "bomb?"

– From Notebook Fragments

. . . the deep-red apple rolling
from her palm, then into the prison cell

where her husband sits staring at the moon
until he's convinced it's the last wafer

god refused him, let it hit his jaw like a kiss
we've forgotten how to give one another, hissing

back to '68, Ha Long Bay: the sky replaced
with fire, the sky only the dead

look up to, may it reach the grandfather f*****
the pregnant farmgirl in the back of his army jeep,

*An American soldier f***** a Vietnamese farmgirl. Thus my mother exists. Thus I exist. Thus no bombs = no family = no me.*

– From Notebook Fragments

his blond hair flickering in napalm-blasted wind, let it pin
him down to dust where his future daughters rise,

fingers blistered with salt & Agent Orange, let them
tear open his olive fatigues, clutch that name hanging

from his neck, that name they press to their tongues
to relearn the word *live, live, live*—but if

for nothing else, let me weave this deathbeam
the way a blind woman stitches a flap of skin back

to her daughter's ribs.

Grandma said, "In the war they would grab a baby, a soldier at each ankle and pull . . ."

– From Notebook Fragments

Yes—let me believe I was born
to cock back this rifle, smooth & slick, like a true

Charlie, like the footsteps of ghosts misted through rain
as I lower myself between the sights—& pray

that nothing moves.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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**Music and Lyrics to White Christmas can be found at*
https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=w9QLn7gM-hY

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